



FITNESSWISE

Ramji Srinivasan



FOR MORE
STORIES

Training load and the illusion of injury prediction

Why coaches and practitioners need to look **beyond workload metrics** when assessing injury risk and athlete readiness.

Training load or TL has become a catchphrase in high-performance sports, plastered across dashboards, athlete monitoring platforms, and return-to-play protocols and planning for each session, cutting across all sports. At first glance, it makes impeccable sense: track how much work athletes do, reduce injury risk, and avoid other complications, right?

Despite widespread adoption, the belief that we can control injury risk through TL manipulation is more hopeful than it is evidence-based.

WHAT IS TRAINING LOAD?

Training load refers to the physical and physiological stress imposed on an athlete during training or competition. It's typically

broken down into:

- ✦ External load: Objective measures like distance, weight lifted, speed, or accelerations.
- ✦ Internal load: The athlete's psychophysiological response to training — heart rate, RPE, blood lactate, etc.

TL is often used to substantiate whether athletes completed the specified work and to monitor how they responded.

THE PROMISE AND MIRAGE OF PROGNOSTIC METRICS

Popular models like the Acute Chronic Workload Ratio (ACWR) have gained traction for quantifying load progression and

More a gauge than a guide: Training load is like a car dashboard. It tells you what's happening currently, but it doesn't drive the car and cannot predict a crash. It's a tool to be used in varied action and reaction potential. GETTY IMAGES

